

Recognize it

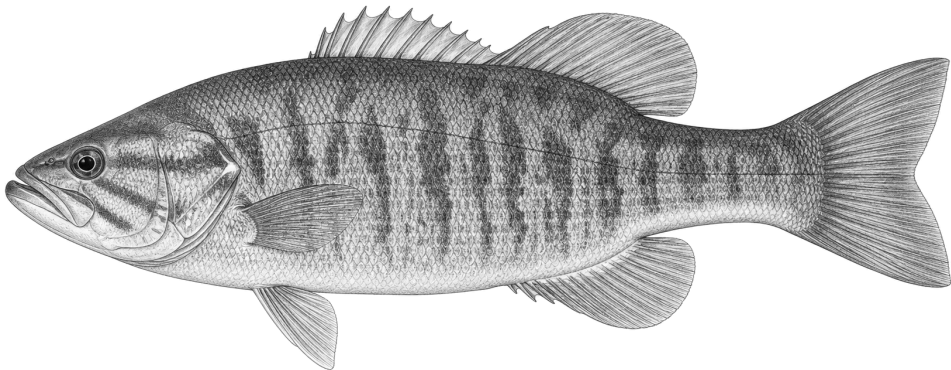
Bronze bass with vertical side bars; closed jaw does not extend beyond rear of eye.

Body	Elongate; dorsal sections connected with a shallow notch.
Mouth/fins	Large mouth smaller than largemouth's; tongue may have tooth patch.
Confusion	Largemouth is greener, has a strong horizontal band, and jaw extends past eye.

Lake role

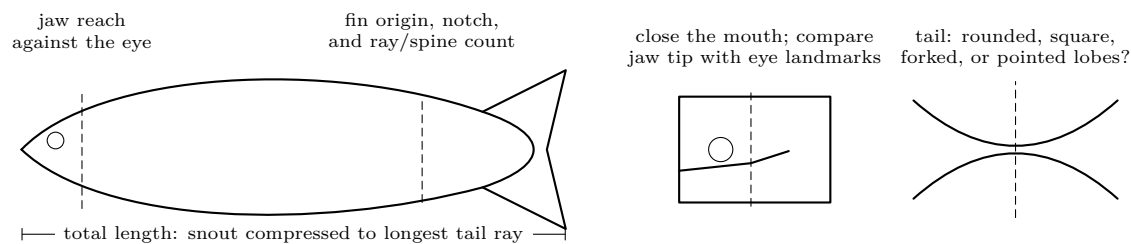
Where it belongs Rock, gravel, points, breaks, and crayfish-rich transitions.
Food and season Crayfish and fish; shifts from warming shallows to deeper hard edges and fall prey routes.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



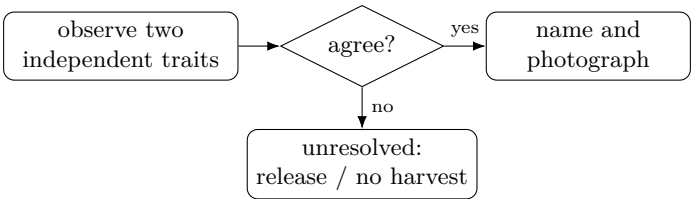
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Close the mouth and verify that the jaw ends near the eye rather than beyond it.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Confirm the shallow connection between spiny and soft dorsal sections.
- 3. **Markings last.** Use vertical bars and bronze tone only after jaw and dorsal checks.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Smallmouth Bass
Nearest alternative	Largemouth is greener, has a strong horizontal band, and jaw extends past eye.
Required gate	Name smallmouth only when jaw reach stops near the eye and the dorsal notch remains shallow.
Independent check	A lateral photograph must show closed jaw, eye, and both dorsal sections in one plane.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test gravel points and steep hard breaks; in clear water use long casts and natural depth control.
North	Test rocky narrows, points, and firm patches beside vegetation or current.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Log bottom contact and substrate; repeated fish without hard-bottom evidence should reopen the habitat hypothesis.

Presentations

1. **Tube or Ned rig.** Drag or short-hop across rock while maintaining bottom contact.
2. **Drop shot.** Hold a small bait above bottom when fish are marked but inactive.
3. **Stop rule.** Change casting angle before lure; if no hard bottom or prey evidence appears, relocate.

On-water verification

After the first response, ask: *Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?* Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Land promptly, wet hands, support large fish level, and reduce air exposure in warm water.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 14-in minimum; bass daily bag 5 combined on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	If keeping one, choose a legal mid-size fish and release large adults; bass fall in predator meal advice.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin's Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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